Historical source

Encyclopaedia Britannica scan, source row 1765. Parse 3.5 extracted the text. Super 3.5 VL corrected it from an enlarged crop of each block. It can still contain recognition errors. Page headers, footers, and page numbers are removed.

Untitled continuation (E0149)

Continues an entry from an earlier page.

Kalmucs, and choleric temperament, they live more amicably together than one could expect in a people that lead to independent a life. They seldom come to blows even over their cups, and their quarrels are hardly ever bloody. A murder very rarely happens, though their anger has something in it exceedingly fierce. It would seem that the morality of their religion, though exceedingly idolatrous, has been able to moderate their natural disposition in this respect; for in consequence of their dogmas, with regard to the transmigration of fouls, every wanton murder either of men or beasts is thought a deadly fin.

The Kalmus are exceedingly affable; and of so social a disposition, that it is rare for a traveller to perceive another, even at the distance of several miles, without going to salute him, and to inquire into the object of his journey. When a troop of Kalmus perceive any person at a distance, it is customary for them to detach one of their number to the next eminence, from whence he makes a signal with his cap for the person to draw near. If this signal is not obeyed, the person is considered as an enemy or a robber, and is often pursued as such. They enter willingly into friendships; but these connexions are not quite disinterested; for to give and to receive presents are with them essential articles. A mere trifle, however, is sufficient to induce them to do you all manner of service; and they are never ungrateful as far as they are able. Adversity cannot deprive them of courage nor alter their good humour. A Kalmus will never beg if he were in the extremity of misery, but rather endeavour to acquire a subsistence by cheating; and when no other way remains, he will hire himself to some rich individual of his nation, or to some Ruffian, either as a herdman, a fisherman, or for any other sort of labour. Very few of the rich value themselves much upon their wealth; but those who do, show no contempt for the poor of their own nation; though the meaner sort pay their court very obsequiously to the rich, who are always surrounded with a swarm of idle dependents.

Nothing can be more prudent than that exercise of hospitality practised by wandering nations: it is of the greatest advantage to those among them who travel across their deserts; and each individual who practises it, may rely on reaping the benefit of it wherever he goes. A Kalmuc provided with a horse, with arms and equipage, may ramble from one place to another for three months together, without taking with him either money or provisions. Wherever he comes he finds either distant relations or friends, to whom he is attached by the ties of hospitality, from whom he meets with the kindest reception, and is entertained in the best manner their circumstances afford. Perhaps he lodges in the first unknown cottage he finds upon his road; and scarce has he entered it, but his wants are supplied with the most affectionate cordiality. Every stranger, of whatsoever nation, never fails to be well received by a Kalmuc; and he may depend upon having his effects in the greatest security the moment he has put himself under the protection of his host: for to rob a guest is considered by the Kalmucs as the most abominable of all crimes.

When the matter of the hoose fits down to meat in company with others of inferior rank, he begins in-

deed by serving himself and his family, but whatever remains is distributed among the affiliates. When they smoke tobacco, the pipe circulates incessantly from one to another. When any one receives a present either of meat or drink, he divides it faithfully with his companions, even though of inferior rank. But they are much more niggardly of their other effects, and especially of their cattle, and do not willingly give these away except when they hope to receive a suitable return : or if any relation has accidentally suffered the loss of his flocks, he is sure to be most willingly afflicted. Perhaps too it may be related as an article of their hospitality, that they abandon their wives to their friends with the greatest facility, and in general they are very little inclined to jealousy.

Their robberies are never committed upon their equals, and even the greater part of the rapine exercised on other tribes is founded on hatred or national quarrels; neither do they willingly attempt this by open force, but prefer the machinations of cunning, which are so natural to them. It must also be confessed, that it is only those that live with princes, and in camps where they hold their courts, or their profits, that are most addicted to these practices; while the common people, satisfied with the pleasures of the pastoral life, spend their days in innocent simplicity, and never attack the property of another till forced by necessity, or led by their superiors who show them the example.

The Kalmucs are very faithful to their lawful prince; they endure every sort of oppression, and yet are with difficulty induced to revolt; but if they belong to a prince who has not become so by right of succession, they very easily rebel. They honour old age. When young men travel with such as are older than themselves they take upon

them the whole care of the cattle as well as of the feast. They are exceedingly prudent in matters that relate to their foreign or their nation, or which are recommended to their direction by the priests, to whom they yield an unrevered obedience.

The moveable habitations of the Kalmus are those felt huts with a conical roof in use among all the roaming Asiatics. The truly ingenious invention of these tents was undoubtedly conceived in the eastern parts of Asia, and most probably by the Mongol nations. As they can be entirely taken to pieces and folded in a small compass, they are very useful, and perfectly agree with the migratory life of these people, who are still ignorant of the use of carriages. The frame of these huts, and the felt they are covered with, though made as light as possible, yet are a sufficient load for a camel or two oxen. But the capacity of these huts, their warmth in winter, their strength in resisting tempests and excluding rain, abundantly compensate for this inconvenience. The wood endures many years; and though the felt begins to break into holes in the second year, the common people, who do not consider it as disgraceful to have them mended and patched, make them serve a good deal longer. The huts are in general use from the prince down to the meanest Kalmuc, differing only in size and in the embellishments within. In winter, they are warm even when heated with the dried excrements of their cattle, to which they are often obliged to have recourse, for

Source record

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